Example c: Contrast (Differences)

When the first baby arrives in a household, everything changes. While before, the mother needed an alarm clock in the morning, now the baby decides when she should wake up. Formerly, the parents spent their evenings watching TV or reading, but not now. All their free time is spent admiring their infant. In contrast to pre-baby days, their life is more carefully planned. While they used to go out to see friends whenever they wanted to, that is not possible any more. If they want to go out without the baby, they must arrange for a babysitter. Unlike the neat and tidy rooms of the past, these days their apartment is full of baby things. Their friends have even noticed a difference in the topic of conversation: it's always about the baby!

Main Idea:_____

_____

Does this paragraph include similarities, (differences), or both?

Signal Words	*Examples*
While before	_____
now	_____
Formerly	_____
not now	_____
In contrast	_____
While they used to	_____
any more	_____
Unlike	_____
difference	_____

exercise 9

➤ ***In these paragraphs, the signal words are not underlined. Read each paragraph. Underline the signal words. Then write the main idea and the signal words and examples on the lines below. Compare your work with another student.***

Modern Versions of Familiar Machines

1. The latest kind of vending machine is nothing like the vending machines of the past. Like the old machines, the new ones are a quick and convenient way to buy food. But the new machines have been improved in several important ways. The old machines worked with coins that were sometimes "swallowed" without providing your food. The new machines, however, work with plastic cards that can be used many times without error. The food supplied by the old machines was usually not very good: stale pastries or tasteless sandwiches. In contrast, the new machines sell all kinds of delicious meals. They may offer fresh, oven-baked pizza, espresso coffee, or fresh pasta. In general, these new machines sell more interesting and better-tasting food.

   Main Idea: _____

   _____

Does this paragraph include similarities, differences, or both?

Signal Words	*Examples*
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____

2. The so-called "portable" computers of just a few years ago were heavy machines. They weighed about 15 pounds and were really designed to stay in one place. The idea of traveling with an old "portable" was out of the question. It would not even fit under an airline seat. Present-day laptop computers, however, are totally different. These "portables" are really meant to be carried around. They are sometimes even called "notebooks." Unlike the heavy monsters of the past, the laptop computers weigh only about five pounds. They can fit easily into a briefcase. In spite of their size, though, they have much more memory capacity than the older computers. Surprisingly, the laptops also have larger screens than the older models.

Main Idea: _____

_____

Does this paragraph include similarities, differences, or both?

Signal Words	*Examples*
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____

3. The next big technological change will be the shift from gasoline to electric-powered automobiles. In some ways, the cars are quite similar. Like gasoline cars, the electric vehicles provide convenient, private transportation. The interior of the two vehicles is much the same. Steering, brakes, and wheels are not different. On the other hand, there is a major difference. Unlike gasoline cars, the electric vehicle is totally silent. In contrast to the sound of the ignition in a gasoline engine, the sound of starting an electric car is "click." There is no engine sound, either, in the electric car.

Main Idea: _____

_____

Does this paragraph include similarities, differences, or both?

Signal Words	*Examples*
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____

exercise 17

In these paragraphs, you may find some "chain reactions." Read each paragraph. Then write the main idea and the cause(s) and effect(s) below. Compare your work with another student.

How Diseases Spread

1. When people move from one city or country to another, the spread of diseases may result. People often bring in germs which may not have been present there before. These new germs can spread quickly and cause previously unknown diseases. If a germ is completely new to a region, people have no natural protection against it. They become ill more easily and die more often. In turn, newcomers may catch diseases which were not present where they came from. If they go back, they may carry the disease with them and start an epidemic there, too.

   Main Idea: _____

   _____

   Cause(s): Effect(s):

2. Changes in heating systems of buildings can also lead to disease. In the 1970s, there was a worldwide shortage of heating oil. To save fuel, hotels in the Unites States lowered the temperature in their heating systems. This lower temperature was just perfect for a deadly germ which grows in heating pipes. When the heated air was blown into the rooms of a hotel, it carried the germs. Many visitors became ill and several died.

   Main Idea: _____

   _____

   Cause(s): Effect(s):

3. Pollution of the oceans can also result in the spread of disease. Phosphates and nitrates from fertilizers plus human waste eventually flow into the oceans. These pollutants result in the increased growth of tiny plants called *algae*. These plants provide a home for cholera, a deadly disease. The infected algae can stick to ships, which then carry the cholera germs all around the world. Germs of the disease recently rode on ships going from India to South America. There, thousands of people have died from the resulting epidemic of cholera.

   Main Idea: _____

   _____

   Cause(s): Effect(s):